

Unit 3 – Section 4: Influences on Business Decisions

Exam Patterns & Trends (2019 – 2025)

Overview of Exam Patterns

Mark Type	Typical Command Words	Frequency	Focus Areas
4 marks	Define / Explain	Every Paper	Concept recall or stakeholder identification questions.
8 marks	Assess	Frequent	Stakeholder conflict, CSR benefits, or culture impact analysis.
12 marks	Discuss	Frequent	Stakeholder priorities, ethical dilemmas, and culture influence.
20 marks	Evaluate	Every Paper	Balanced argument evaluating long-term vs short-term ethics, CSR, or culture outcomes.

AO Weighting: AO1 (20%), AO2 (25%), AO3 (25%), AO4 (30%)

Topic Trend Analysis (2019 – 2025)

Topic	Year & Question Reference	Command Words	Trend Summary
Corporate Culture	2020 Jan Q2b, 2022 Jun Q3a, 2023 Oct Q2d	Explain / Evaluate	Appears every 2–3 sessions; focuses on Handy’s culture types and cultural integration post-

Stakeholders vs Shareholders	2019 Oct Q3, 2021 Jan Q1d, 2024 Jun Q1b	Explain / Discuss	merger. Frequent 8–12 mark topic analysing conflicting objectives and stakeholder mapping.
Business Ethics & CSR	2020 Jun Q3c, 2022 Jan Q3a, 2023 Jun Q2b	Assess / Evaluate	Common 12–20 mark topic evaluating ethical trade-offs and CSR benefits vs costs.

Predicted Focus for Jan 2026 Exam

Predicted Topic	Mark	Command Word	Likely Context
Corporate Culture	12	Discuss	“Discuss whether a strong corporate culture always leads to business success.”
Stakeholders vs Shareholders	8	Assess	“Assess whether stakeholder priorities are more important than shareholder returns.”
Business Ethics & CSR	20	Evaluate	“Evaluate whether ethical behaviour enhances or limits competitiveness in global markets.”

Teacher Revision Tips

- Link this section with Unit 3.3.1 objectives and Unit 3.3.2 growth for context.
- Use real case studies (e.g., Starbucks, Patagonia, Unilever, BP) to show CSR and ethical trade-offs.
- Encourage balanced evaluation using “depends on” and time-frame discussion.
- Highlight differences between ethics (morals) and CSR (action).

- Reinforce Handy's culture types (Power, Role, Task, Person) and their impact on change management.

Key Takeaways

- Corporate Culture and CSR dominate 20-mark evaluative questions.
- Stakeholder vs Shareholder conflict often features in 8–12 mark questions.
- AO4 performance improves when students balance ethics with profit motives.
- Jan 2026 may feature an integrated CSR + stakeholder scenario question.
- Linking examples like Apple, Google, or Tesco strengthens contextual analysis.